asking him to submit to Akbar and demonstrate his loyalty, the Uzbek chieftain decided to flee to Gujarat instead, seeking the protection of that powerful sultanate, marking the beginning of open hostilities between Akbar and the Uzbek clan.

When Abdullah Khan had initially tried to prevaricate, before his flight to Gujarat, there were skirmishes and battles and Akbar himself led the imperial troops in a charge. When a foolhardy amir suggested that Akbar not endanger himself, Akbar was so enraged that he turned his horse around to face the man, his hand immediately on his sword. The man, one Khaksar Sultan, understanding his folly at once, jumped nimbly off his own horse and ran away through the stampeding horses of the other soldiers. But Akbar's vast anger would not be contained and he charged after the man. Akbar struck Khaksar Sultan with his sword but 'since the blade was an Indian Khanda',* Abu'l Fazl pointed out, 'it did not kill him' and the man lived to regret the impertinence of trying to question the young Padshah.

The Mughal troops harassed and chased Abdullah Khan till one day, with the ancient golden ruins of Champaner in the distance, they hurtled down a hillside, banners fluttering with the Timurid symbols of the lion and the sun, scimitars gleaming, screaming out their battle cry, 'Allahu Akbar!' and the Uzbek chief fled, abandoning his valuables, his goods, his horses, his elephants, and all his womenfolk, and Malwa was conclusively annexed to the Mughal Empire. After this decisive victory, Akbar gave high promotions to those who had distinguished themselves, for the first time since 1560, strengthening a core of noblemen whose loyalty to the Padshah was now proven. Some of the men recorded as having taken part in these battles included two kokas, Aziz Khan and Saif Khan, in addition to Munim Khan, the eunuch Itimad Khan, Asaf Khan and, for the first time, a certain Raja Todar Mal.† Qara Bahadur Khan was appointed to the governorship of Mandu and, in the middle of pouring rain, with the drummers leading the procession, the imperial retinue headed back to Agra. One particularly fascinating manuscript is believed to have entered the Mughal imperial library at this time along with other treasures from Mandu. This was the *Nimat-khana* (Book of Pleasures), an illustrated collection of recipes, aphrodisiacs and perfumes, commissioned by the aesthete and gourmet ruler of Mandu, Sultan Ghiyath Shah, earlier in the sixteenth century. Akbar rode mast elephants most of the way back, including one particularly ferocious animal named Khandi Rai. En route the king of Khandesh, Miran